

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1536

By Jones J

A RESOLUTION to honor the 150th anniversary of the Colored National Convention held at the Tennessee State Capitol in Nashville.

WHEREAS, the Colored National Convention held at the Tennessee State Capitol in Nashville on April 5-7, 1876, was a significant Reconstruction-era assembly focused on voting rights, civil rights, and political strategy for African Americans; its attendees included prominent political leaders, educators, and organizers; and

WHEREAS, held during our nation's centennial year, the Colored National Convention highlighted the disparity between American ideals of freedom and the lived experience of Black citizens; and

WHEREAS, through the leadership of its prominent members, the convention passed resolutions demanding Civil Rights Defense, a call for African Americans to use the courts to defend their rights; Education Funding, a request for Congress to provide \$7 million for public education in the South; and Labor Reform, a demand for a Congressional committee to investigate Southern labor and improve economic conditions, aiming for equal wages; and

WHEREAS, the 1876 Colored Convention was documented in contemporary media, including a famous wood engraving, based on a photograph by Carl Caspar Giers, which was published in Frank Leslie's *Illustrated Newspaper* on May 6, 1876; and

WHEREAS, this wood engraving vividly illustrates a historic moment in the struggle for African-American civil rights by showcasing the gathering of Black leaders advocating for equal rights, education, and economic opportunities during the Reconstruction era; and

WHEREAS, today, this piece serves as a powerful reminder of the resilience and determination of those who fought for a better future; and

WHEREAS, the 1876 Colored Convention was part of a larger, long-term Black convention movement spanning the 1830s–1880s that was aimed at asserting citizenship and responding to the rise of violent oppression and disenfranchisement in the South through political engagement and community unity; and

WHEREAS, overall, the Colored Conventions, such as the one held in Nashville in 1876, reflect the long history of collective Black mobilization before, during, and long after the end of the Civil War; and

WHEREAS, as empowering hubs of Black political thought and organizing, the Colored Conventions provided space for informed public audiences to develop political plans and community-building projects, celebrate racial unity and protest state violence, and work tirelessly to secure Black people's civil rights; and

WHEREAS, as we celebrate the 250th anniversary of the founding of the United States of America, it is most appropriate that we should honor those historic events that remind us of how far we have come and how far we have yet to go; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the 150th anniversary of the Colored National Convention held at the Tennessee State Capitol in Nashville on April 5-7, 1876, reflecting upon its historical significance and its pivotal role in assuring equality under the law for Black citizens.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.